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Jordan River surfing area to be tested for pollution

Amy Smart / Times Colonist

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Mine deposit on bank of Jordan River in photo from 2005. Photograph By Courtesy of David Burt

The Capital Regional District will test a popular Jordan River surfing area, following reports that a closed mine may have contaminated the beach.

Mike Hicks, Juan de Fuca electoral area director, said he believes the beaches of Jordan River Regional Park are safe, but the measure will be taken as a precaution. A 2011 stormwater quality test found copper in the Jordan River, which feeds into the ocean near recreational beaches.

“They tested above the bridge in the river and it showed some copper content, but nothing alarming. We’ll be going down to our park beach to do some testing and make double-sure that everything’s OK,” Hicks said.

Sunro Mine, which produced 1.3 million tonnes of copper and gold between 1962 and 1978, has been identified as the source of copper contamination in the river.

Salmon had disappeared by the time mining operations wrapped in the mid-1970s. In addition to copper contamination, stocks were also threatened by nearby logging and reduced water flows from B.C. Hydro’s dam.

In August, after the site was identified as “high risk,” the Ministry of Environment ordered Teck Metals and Western Forest Products to prepare a remediation plan and schedule by June 2017.

Several University of Victoria studies have found the contamination extended beyond the river to the shoreline.

In 1991, graduate student Caleen Kilby found a heavy mineral placer had formed along Sandcut Beach and in shallow water out to 800 metres from shore, identifying Sunro Mine as the source.

In a 2008 issue of Marine Pollution: New Research, UVic biologist Derek Ellis wrote that the mine had been permitted to use a very shallow submarine tailings pipe, which led from the mine into the ocean, on the wave-exposed coast.

“In hindsight, this was obviously a mistake. The pipeline broke several times, and although all but the last break was repaired, much of the tailings drifted inshore and contaminated shellfish,” Ellis wrote.

The Jordan River itself has been the focus of efforts to revive salmon populations for years, largely led by the Pacheedaht First Nation, in partnership with B.C. Hydro. The project, which has involved releasing enough steady water from the dam to support fish populations, is starting to see some success.

Consulting biologist Dave Burt said 20 to 25 adult coho and half a dozen adult chum have returned. But contamination and limited habitat continue to pose barriers.

“Other species have been spotty: The odd steelhead has been observed and a few pinks in some years. At this point, the river is severely limited in spawning habitat, rearing habitat and estuarine nursery habitat,” Burt said in an email.

A hydrological study of the lower river is underway to see whether spawning gravel for pink and chum salmon is feasible, said resource restoration biologist Margaret Wright, who is providing technical support as part of Fisheries and Oceans Canada.

Another study is looking at the feasibility of establishing off-channel habitat for coho and chum, Wright said.

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